DRAFT 1:

Preface - Trauma Bonding

United in struggle, divided by strength.
Together we see and march at great length.
Through borders, generations and cultures we seek.
A shared understanding of how things got so bleak.

I invite you to ask yourself a simple question. Right now, here in this very moment, do you truly feel your life is the best it ever was? If you're young, do you think you're living better than your parents, or your grandparents? If you have kids or grandkids yourself, was there not a time when things were just… easier? Better? When the future was bright and everything was exactly as it should be? There's probably never been a 'perfect' moment. But I think it is safe to say we are all feeling, for one reason or another, like right now is possibly the hardest it's ever been.

When we're young, I think we tend to gaslight ourselves in order to make sense of the situation we find ourselves in. Why is it unreasonable for us to expect that when you're brought into this world by two people you've never met without any consideration or consent, that we might deserve certain basic 'privileges' such as food, shelter and education? Not just when we're small and defenceless but also when we're grown and supposedly now valuable to society. Why is it that we must fight to prove our worth? Why is it not simply enough that we exist… that we're here? Why is it that some people are seemingly more deserving of this than others? What if we were born to stupidly rich parents… wouldn't life be so much easier.?

For those of us who are a bit older, those feelings don't magically disappear either. We can rationalise as much as we want about why the world is the way it is. The 'natural order' of things. Our cynicism hardens around us like calloused skin, protecting us from daydreaming about a world that makes sense. After all, we've seen it all, right? At what point did we lose hope? Was it when we had to take those extra shifts to keep up with our mortgage payments that just keep getting bigger? Was it when, despite working all those extra shifts, Brian from HR sat us down to tell us we were being made redundant - not because the company was struggling but in the name of 'restructuring', whatever the fuck that means? Or was it when your neighbour who worked in consulting who seems to spend 3/5 days of the week playing golf brought home that obnoxious green sports car that you can hear coming down the road 10 minutes before it actually arrives?

We might be separated by age, gender, sexuality, nationality or even language but one thing holds true for the vast majority. It feels like we're running, just to keep our head a few millimetres above the water. Like the closer we get to where we're trying to be, the faster it moves away from us. Don't get me wrong. A fortunate few are able to make it out of this never-ending rat race but the rest of us will be lucky if we ever even own our own homes. We'll be lucky if we have anything at all to pass on to our children when we leave this Earth aside from care home and funeral bills and generational trauma.

Fuel and energy prices are spiralling out of control, there's more adverts on TV now than there is actual television, now you need to buy your phone charger separately from your phone. The local shops are all closing down. A loaf of bread has gone up over 130% in the last 20 years but guess how much wages have increased in that same period? There's less Pringles in a can, more administrative fees in your bank statements. There's less jobs that you qualify for and twice as many people applying for the ones that you do. And these phenomenon aren't just shaking the bottom rungs of the social ladder, the middle and upper middle classes are getting squeezed for every penny they're worth as well. Your landlord isn't just putting your rent up because he's greedy and selfish. The risk that you and all the other tenants in your building won't be able to pay your rent next year is compounding. The prices of utilities are getting out of hand, as are university tuition fees. How can he be sure he can send his kids off to university to get a decent education and a reasonable job if he's taking home less and less money every single year?

And that's just what's happening on our doorstep, don't get me started on global affairs. How is it that a literal clown is elected to become the president of one of the most powerful nations in the world, not just once… but twice?! How is it that in the 21st Century, we still find ourselves arguing over whether or not a victim of sexual assault should have the right to abort the child? Why are we still bombing schools and sending our children overseas to fight people we've never met on land we've never stepped foot on to stop missiles that were never launched? Why are we spending so much money 'liberating' foreign countries from oppressive regimes when we have homeless veterans begging for spare change right here on our own turf? Why do we even need to tell Google explicitly that we don't want them to pawn off our data so we can watch even more painful advertisements?

We may disagree on many things, but I firmly believe that we can cast those sticky points aside for the time being. What we're facing right now is an assault on all that was promised by our leaders and all that we deserve as human beings. Everything that humanity has collectively strived for is being unraveled at an increasingly alarming rate. Our ancestors fought off diseases, fascism, slavery and natural disasters so that we could eventually live with dignity and hope for the future. I am writing this essay because like many other people, I am tired of the doom and gloom. I am tired of constantly being told 'this is the best we've got' or that 'things will be different this time' when even new geopolitical events carry clear traces of the past. If we have any hope at building a brighter future, the time to fight is now.

So what, exactly, are we fighting for?

Chapter 1 - Why is everything so shit?

'If you know the enemy and know yourself, you need not fear the result of a hundred battles." - Sun Tzu, The Art of War

Before we can understand the causes of our struggles right now, we must first be able to point to why exactly things are so deeply upsetting and, especially, be able to agree on them. We cannot wage war on an enemy we cannot see or, worse, we cannot hope to defeat our enemies if everybody names a different one. If we can at least agree that things are pretty shit right now, then we should be able to name at least a few measurable

phenomena that might explain the rotten smell around us. In this section, we'll dive into what I believe to be some of the most powerful phenomena that are hijacking our sense of self, as well as our social fabric.

We are not in control of our own destiny.

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Human civilisation is frankly one of the most powerful forces of nature this planet has ever seen. Never before has a single species been so productive but also disruptive of natural systems and physical limitations. We have built mega cities, sent people and animals to space with rockets up their ass, sent robots to Mars, submarines to the bottom of the ocean, we routinely catapult aluminium cans full of people to different continents for vacations, we've eradicated diseases, engineered plants to feed us and now walk around with computers in our pocket capable of sending instant transmissions to every other human on the planet or trading stocks from train station cubicles. Whatever your political orientation, it is undeniable that our species has achieved and continues to achieve unprecedented feats. Some people might label this as blasphemy but we are quite literally the ancient god that many of us continue to worship to this day. But despite having immense collective power including labour, science, social organisation, automation and capital formation, we feel among us a deep sense of frustration like a toddler who can't quite walk yet. There is so much inherent potential in our existence as a human species of which we are reminded of every single day and, yet, we feel completely incompetent and alienated from the magical powers that we wield. We can feel the sheer magnitude of our power but rather than feeling it emanate from us, we instead feel it exerted unto us. As if this insatiable human current is pushing in exactly the opposite direction than the one we're trying to swim.

I would hope I don't need to say too much to prove this to you, but instead ask you to reflect on some questions:

If billions of people don't want war, environmental collapse, or inequality, why do they keep happening?

OR

How can a species powerful enough to change the climate be unable to change its own direction?

You might not personally believe in climate change. You may even believe that war is justified but the numbers don't lie. 80% of people believe their governments should be taking stronger action to prevent ecological collapse [INSERT REF] and, yet, we continue to accelerate towards irreversible change. So why is it that there is such a huge difference between what *we* want and what actually ends up happening on the global stage?

We can go a step further as well. What we're facing right now is not simply embarrassment that we have no control over our own collective and individual fate, but also that there are a smaller subset of the population that *do* seem to have control and are able to enact their will against public interest. Physical wars and threats, economic instability (e.g. the 2008 financial crisis, recent oil and gas price spikes), data sovereignty and climate change are all problems that burden the majority of us and, as such, it would be difficult for most people to argue that these are outcomes that they support. Yet, all of these issues are ultimately decided on and/or caused by a much, much smaller portion of the global population.

The 2008 financial crisis was caused by corruption and widespread complacency in the financial sector, cost us globally billions of dollars, resulted in a long period of austerity and higher financial pressure on the ordinary taxpayer but, despite being the ones who directly caused the collapse, banks who had executives and employees that made fortunes in bonuses leading up to and throughout the crisis were voluntarily bailed out by the government (i.e. **YOU**). People like us may have been forced to take a second job or take on predatory loans to stay afloat but for the banks, business as usual.

Another thing which you've probably noticed - especially after the bombing of Iran is that oil, gas and energy prices just continue to increase putting the squeeze on all of us that still rely on fossil fuels to get by. The price of these commodities has increased as a direct result of US and Israeli military operations that killed Iran's Supreme Leader and continue to generate civilian casualties. Again, you might have your own position on whether or not Iran's regime was a threat to US national security but had you had all of the information upfront and were actually given the choice to carry out foreign military operations right now that will surely disrupt global supply chains for fossil fuels, you probably wouldn't have voted in favour.

There is this sort of illusion of choice which comes about as a result of how ideas are presented to the general public. You can, for example, be in favour of increasing military spending but probably not if it means your children's schools will lose funding. But it's never presented to you like that is it? Political issues are most frequently represented as single-dimension pro/anti- choices, without considering the widespread and interconnected effects every change in policy has on our every day lives. Some of us may genuinely care about geopolitical stability in the middle-east but for the vast majority, we just want to know our children are safe, we can feed them and we can keep a roof over our heads. When you constrain our collective priorities to those basic interests, almost none of what's happening in the world at the moment could be considered *our* choice.

Basic human dignity is becoming increasingly expensive.

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As I mentioned, for most of us, our ambition is not global domination, increasing shareholder value or being a world leader in smartphone innovation. We just want to eat, to laugh, to love, to sing. We deserve that much. And it's really not that much to ask for is it? Being born should be a beautiful thing, a celebration of life, a marvel of human creation but instead it rather feels like a debt we owe to the world that many of us will never pay off. We didn't choose to be here, but damn us if we don't display our gratitude by giving as much of ourselves back through blood, sweat and tears to serve humanity. Personally, I don't even have such a big problem with this idea of giving back to society, in fact, for me I'd say it is indeed my life's purpose. But slaving away 6 days a week just to feed myself, pay my landlord for a room that would otherwise sit unoccupied and give some schmuck an exponentially increasing annual bonus so he can buy my building and increase the rent again for some strange reason just doesn't sit right with me.

I'm very fortunate to have been born where I was to the family I was. My parents never had much but they did keep a roof over my head, shoes on my feet and food in my belly. As I'm sure you're aware, many billions of people on this planet are not so fortunate. For many, in order to achieve the same levels of baseline economic security, they cannot simply sell their time. No no, they are forced to sell their body and/or their dignity too to maintain a frugal existence. I think though that we're all doing it to some extent. There are clear extremes, particularly for much of the global south, but all of us to one degree or another must make great sacrifice to 'earn' basic human dignity.

Lastly, I think we can all agree that, not only must we make great sacrifice to satisfy our basic needs, but the amount of sacrifice we must make to maintain our livelihoods exactly as they are right now is increasing every single year. In the US, earlier generations were fortunate in that working 3 or 4 solid years under an average income eventually afforded them the ability to purchase their own home. Nowadays, you'd be lucky if you own a home before you reach your 40s (approximately halfway through your life) working 2 or 3 jobs, 6 or 7 days a week. So the premise didn't exactly start off great; 'Earn your dignity'. Now it's simply an atrocious proposition; 'Work harder and harder and maybe, if you're lucky, earn your dignity'. It's no wonder kids these days don't want to work.

This whole situation is made way, way worse when you contrast it with the fact that some people (~0.1%) have more wealth than your entire family tree since the start of history. Whilst you bust your ass to provide for 2 or perhaps 4 people if you have children, there are individuals whose wealth is so vast that they make your entire annual salary in passive income in the time it takes them to take a shit. You can include your partner's salary in that too if you include the wipe. How many shits do you think they take every year? On a diet of caviar and oysters I'd hazard a guess that it's a lot more than 365. Levels of inequality are at the highest they have ever been, even when compared to feudal times. At a time in history where we seem to have the most power, knowledge and technology available to us at the lowest cost to produce it, why is it that we are still struggling so hard to meet our basic needs on both an individual and collective level?

Plop.

In addition to the economic war that's being waged on us ordinary folk, in its shadow hides an equally unsettling political one. For the younger generations, we never had to directly fight for many of our basic human rights. We take them for granted because we had them and had no real perspective on how much sacrifice and conflict was required to achieve them. Our ancestors fought physical and emotional battles for centuries to get us to where we are today. We liberated ourselves from slavery, humiliation and total oppression and constructed constitutions, policies and organisations that existed to protect those very rights. Now, constitutions are being ignored and those policies and institutions are being dismantled, exposing us once again to the threat of complete domination from tyrants. Criminalising protests, as happened recently in the UK, is not just about maintaining public order. It is a direct and real threat to democracy as we know it. Many people can agree that the 'Just Stop Oil' protests were disruptive and annoying but what about when they start rounding up non-rich people and send them to the furnace? You'd better hope you stood up for your right to protest.

Heads I win, tails you lose.

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A lot of people want to argue that inequality is just fair game. That there are winners and losers and some people deserve to win more than others. I could imagine a world where this might indeed be the case but let me tell you, it's going to look very different than the one we live in today. Let's use some real examples to illustrate this point:

In my field of expertise, there is a big international conference every year in Paris where thousands of students and young professionals travel across the globe to network, show off their work and compete to win prizes and recognition. When you're just starting out, this is literally *the* conference to attend if you want to make something of yourself in this profession. For a team to participate in the competition, they need to pay a $5,500

registration fee which doesn't necessarily include the cost of the experiments they need to do. In addition, they must each spend upwards of $2,500 to secure a ticket to the conference, pay the judges of the competition and pay for travel and accommodation. For middle class students, that's not a huge burden. After all, it's an *investment* in their future. But what about for those students that not only occupy the working class but also were perhaps born in countries with a weaker economy? If a student from Uganda (a country in Africa with a relatively strong biology research capacity) whose parents earned the average salary of $201/month, it would take them at least 2 years to save up for this even if they saved 50% of their entire salary every month. Obviously 50% savings is extremely unrealistic. It's much more likely that it would take them closer to 10 years to save for this opportunity, if at all. And this conference doesn't even guarantee you of getting a job.

It's easy for us to say that people should just roll their sleeves up and pull themselves out of poverty, but the reality is that most of them are starting from such an extreme disadvantage that they never stood a chance. But this is all the way over in Africa, for many of us, that's a completely different reality we've never seen nor lived. So what about Europe? The United States?

In Europe, we have strong national and regional inequality. Regardless of the city you visit, you will frequently see homeless people begging for change on the subway or outside of nice restaurants and cafes. There are immigrants who clean the bathrooms/buildings in diners who frequently throw away food. How many Latvian or Lithuanian consultants do you meet? Is it because Latvians and Lithuanians aren't good at business? Of course not. It's because they were 'un-lucky' enough to be born there. From my visits to the US and conversations with colleagues and friends, it's even worse. There seems to be a weaponisation of dependence on health insurance, combined with multiple public health crises which keeps the vast majority of the lower rungs of society pretty locked in to a pretty exploitative model.

Additionally, globalisation appears to be the perfect moat to sustain the oppression of the working class. As is the case in Europe and the US, imperialist countries are always within relatively close proximity to economies that are 'worse off'. Therefore, there is a stable supply of cheap labour, cheap exports and cheap manufacturing capacity that can effectively undercut the domestic population. In other words, there is always someone who will do your job for less money, which 1) stops you from being able to ask for more and 2) drives down the mean average compensation rate for unspecialised labour. The result of this over the past few decades is that more and more people from other, usually poorer, countries want to come to ours and work. That's why it's quite a common sentiment amongst the working class populations who were born in a country that they can no longer recognise nor relate to their neighbours. You yourself might have found yourself tutting and sighing when the person helping you at the self-checkout can hardly speak English. You may even have a deep sense that your country and local values are under direct attack from immigration. I don't want to debate whether or not that is something we should or shouldn't accept in this essay, but it is important to recognise that there isn't a coordinated effort from outsiders to invade or steal our country's resources. If there is anyone to point the finger at in this situation, it is your employer and government representatives who believe that it is perfectly reasonable to sell off our jobs to the international labour market so that they can minimise their costs.

I'll bring one more example from the other end of the spectrum to illustrate my point. Have you ever played monopoly? Have you ever played monopoly with someone who achieved dominance pretty early on… buying all of the properties, collecting all the rent?

Now imagine that person was also able to change the rules of the game such as how much rent you must pay when you land on their property, how little taxes they pay when the card comes up or how much money each player got when they passed go. It's pretty easy to see then how, every decision, every action in the game could be engineered in their favour and how it'd eventually end up impossible for you to compete with them. The game might go on for hours, days even but your chances of reaching their financial success would ultimately be pretty slim regardless of the timespan. That, my friend is the world we live in today. Wealth is power and power creates more wealth. If you didn't have it to begin with, you're unlikely to have it by the end.

What we see and what we can't.

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One of the other reasons why things feel so crappy right now is that we're trying to fight battles in a world we don't actually see all that well. Imagine having a sword fight with sand in your eyes. You might be able to protect yourself against the first couple of blows but, in the end, you never really stood a chance.

Let me be clear, it is not your fault. The world, especially right now, is incredibly vast and complex and we were never designed to be able to process and integrate this much information at such a high frequency, much less analyse and understand it. Your brain, albeit an incredibly powerful processing unit is no supercomputer. And even if it were, you're still bound by mortal constraints such as the need to eat, the desire to replicate, to rest or play. Most of us are not able to process information without inserting our selves in the middle of it. Some might argue this is by design but that's a neuroscience conversation for another day. Every time we hear something, we need to somehow integrate it into our mental model. What does it mean? How will it affect our past, present and future? Will it 'break' certain beliefs we hold or assumptions we've been clinging on to? So when your senses are bombarded with information from different sources, with different implications and often outright contradictory implications, it's only human to feel overwhelmed. The result of this overwhelm can go one of two ways. Either we lock in, or we log out. Locking in is the process by which we commit ourselves faithfully to a belief system or a certain way of seeing the world. Anything that doesn't fit within this paradigm, we simply ignore or refute in order to grant ourselves some kind of imaginary ideological security. It's feels much more safe to move through the world in this way because we know exactly how to act or react in new situations or with new information. Locking in isn't inherently bad. In fact, when the world is changing around us at such an unprecedented rate and when people come and go from our lives bringing often bringing with them dangerous ideas or physical waves of destruction, it can indeed be a positive thing to hold on to your values. The problem with locking in is that it tends to happen defensively rather than proactively. We lock in as a direct consequence of being embarrassed, lied to or wronged so that we can isolate ourselves from external influence. But sometimes that external influence is a good thing. Sometimes we *should* change our mind about something. After all, many of these beliefs were formed during early years of development as a child and, as such, often do not fit with the reality we come to occupy as adults.

Logging out has almost exactly the same outcome but the mechanism is very different. Instead of actively defending our point of view or attacking those that oppose it, we simply decide we're not going to think about it at all. When someone says they 'don't follow politics' or that they're 'apolitical', what they actually mean is that they've logged out. They're protecting their internal peace by creating an impenetrable wall through which no controversial opinions can reach them. There is truly no such thing as being

apolitical. If you're a human, with a brain who occupies space and shares it with other humans, politics affects almost every part of your life - whether you like it or not. Once again, logging out isn't inherently bad. As someone who refused to watch or read the news or vote in elections for a significant portion of their adult life, I can absolutely understand what drives a person to log out. I'd even go as far as to say that in some circumstances in modern society, it is simply necessary to preserve one's sanity. But again, the harm comes from not opening yourself up to the possibility of growth or change, as well as removing yourself from the very sphere of political activity whereby you and your fellow community members could actually have a say in your collective fate.

I can't close this section without also highlighting that information is unfortunately not this immutable transfer of facts and truth between fellow humans. Our worldviews are largely shaped by the information we receive and the way in which we receive it. If you consider for a moment that the sources through which you gather information might be lying to you, misrepresenting facts or even have ulterior motives then one must draw the conclusion that many of our opinions and ways of thinking are not in fact our own. A social media influencer telling you not to believe what you hear on the news isn't revolutionary or independent thought. You're replacing one external stream of information with another. It takes true independent critical thought to evaluate those streams independently of each other and decide which, if any, can be trusted.

The world changes faster than we can.

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I don't think there could be a better time to write this than now, simply for the fact that we're right in the middle of possibly one of the most disruptive moments in the history of work and labour; the AI renaissance. I've personally witnessed the transition from home computers to laptops, landline phones to mobile, iPods to iPhones, petrol cars to electric ones, direct messaging to social media. I feel pretty seasoned in technological shifts and how they affect, or don't affect the way in which society works but this one is different. First of all, it's happening faster than I remember any of the other transitions happening and, secondly, the scale of impact is orders of magnitude higher than most of the other developments. AI is already changing how people are thinking about work, writing and publication, creative arts, entrepreneurship, medicine and healthcare, therapy and the list goes on and on. There have already been thousands of layoffs as a result of an increased reliance on AI and global capital has within only a couple of years almost entirely been redirected towards AI or AI-adjacent industries. I don't think it's going to slow down either. It's possible that this is now the new pace of change in the world and, like all big cultural shifts, we must either adapt or be left behind.

But this isn't a new phenomenon, it's simply an accelerated version of what has been happening at an increasingly fast rate since the Industrial Revolution. That is to say that the world is constantly changing through a series of paradigm shifts driven by technology, ideology and environmental factors. We humans and our role in this world are an unfortunate casualty of this series of peaceful (but sometimes non-peaceful) revolutions. It is extremely difficult for us, no matter our age, to keep up with these developments and redefine ourselves within the new paradigm, only to have to destroy ourselves once again every 10, then 5 and now every 2 years.

Change in and of itself shouldn't be such a difficult thing but what makes these changes both different and difficult is two things: 1) the changes we face are often so fundamental that they rather painfully disrupt our worldview and 2) because we're far too busy trying to *survive* our current reality that we simply don't have the time to keep up with the substrate change around us. It's like repotting a houseplant into a completely

different pot of soil every 24 hours. By the time the plant has decided whether or not this particular substrate is good for it or not, or how it will begin to organise its roots to get the nutrients and water that it needs, it finds itself in a completely new pot of soil and has to start the process all over again. We're simply not built to endure such radical change at such high frequency. I'd argue this is one of the biggest contributing factors to why we feel so lost and powerless all of the time and why it is near enough impossible for us to find a stable state or sufficiently learn the 'rules' of the game so that we can come out on top.

The lonely forest.

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The irony of our current situation is that we are more connected (physically) than we've ever been and yet many of us feel more isolated than ever. Technology, specifically the internet and social media have made sure that we're all in contact with hundreds or thousands of other people at almost every minute of every day. We feel their pain, we hear their cries, we envy their wins. Whether positive or negative, there is just so much external influence on our internal state right now that furthers this feeling of 'I am not in control'.

Take genocide and war crimes as an example which have been happening around the world for as long as we've had weapons and imperial interests. But for many ordinary people back then, life continued on as normal. It was only a select few curious individuals who might have been aware of the atrocities being carried out overseas in the name of their nations/empires. Today, we're witnessing the most publicly documented humanitarian crises ever thanks to social technology. Within minutes of it happening, we can watch video footage of missiles hitting schools and hospitals, children being pulled from the rubble or the ribcages of men and women piercing their own chests due to starvation and malnutrition. Information coming through our centralised media channels is inherently being filtered and/or manipulated but, to a large extent, it's all there for us to see regardless.

It doesn't matter where you land on the political spectrum, we are hardwired to respond emotionally but also biochemically to witnessing such atrocious scenes. Those who deny that this is deeply unsettling to see, regardless of who the victims are are simply *locked in* or *logged out*. We can't ignore what we see with our own eyes and those images will subconsciously haunt us with every step we take. Our daily lives require us to continually show up often as a positive, enthusiastic and pleasant energy, totally ignoring the reality facing millions overseas or at home.

To be connected in such a way is deeply powerful and is ultimately a breeding ground for so much positive alignment, transparency and accountability. But one must recognise what we also lose in this process as well. When we open ourselves up to the borderless diffusion of ideas, information and experiences we are faced with an uncomfortable truth: If we are not in control who, exactly, is?

Things we don't need.

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"We buy things we don't need with money we don't have to impress people we don't like"
— Fight Club

My final contribution to why the world is so shit right now is, in many ways, about the moving/distorted vision of success. Pre-consumerism, collective aspiration used to drive us towards owning a home, having children and being able to both provide for them and

pass something on to them when we leave this Earth. As a result of consumer and popular culture, young people nowadays dream about fast cars, easy money, fame and material wealth. This is not in and of itself problematic, but the means through which one can achieve these is inherently short-lived and somewhat meaningless. Furthermore, these ends are often pursued *instead of* traditional pursuits which were much more rooted around social security for oneself and one's kin. I am by no means a traditionalist. It is highly likely I will never have children of my own and I certainly do not subscribe to the nuclear family model or relationship styles. However, despite this fact I do carry some nostalgia for when things weren't so complicated. This is also in spite of the fact that I probably never lived in the period for which I feel such a deep nostalgia. What I equate this feeling to instead is a romanticism of core values, values that we have traded for materialism. When I walk into a room of my peers, I'm far more likely to become the object of desire if I place the keys to my Lamborghini on the table rather than a pacifier for my baby. Rationalists would argue that this is because owning a Lamborghini has implications about my personal wealth, meaning that I am perceived as a more attractive and reliable mate. A bit of common sense would tell you that people that drive Lamborghinis statistically don't make good dads *or* husbands.

Clearly we have surpassed common sense if this is the new norm. Instead of collecting assets and building secure wealth to elevate our social status, we have regressed to what some may call 'conspicuous consumption'. Conspicuous consumption is the idea that wealth has become performative. It is now more important to use wealth not just to satisfy needs but to be seen spending it. Believe it or not, there was a time in history that even the wealthiest looked down on this kind of behaviour as it was seen as classless and a differentiator between genuine generational wealth and 'new money' as they call it.

Granted, we common folk have for many years now had aspirations of fame and fortune. But crucially, what has changed now is the 'why'. This intentional perversion of our desire to escape the economic limitations we were born in has both enabled the modern elite class to rub our noses in their wealth and not want to cut off their heads at the guillotine, as well as completely confuse us and our youth as to why we pursue wealth in the first place. Once again, we lose sight of what we're fighting for - meaning the fight was already lost.

Chapter 2 - *How* is everything so shit?

In the first chapter, we built a taxonomy of why everything feels so shit right now. This is obviously not an exhaustive list of all of the problems we are currently experiencing, but I have tried my best to point to some of the biggest contributors to our collective misery. To cover as much theoretical ground as possible, we went pretty deep into some of these ideas, but I do also believe it is worth reiterating and summarising them so that we can metaphorically 'close the book' and move forwards with a more concise mental model.

So, to reiterate, the dissonance we're feeling comes from the following:

1. We are an extraordinarily powerful species with no apparent ability to control or use our power to carry out our collective aims.
2. It is becoming increasingly expensive and, therefore, difficult to meet our basic human needs and live dignified lives.
3. Institutions and policies that we historically fought for that were designed to protect our interests are being actively dismantled.

4. If life is a game, it is unfairly rigged in favour of those who already started the game with a massive advantage.
5. The formation of our worldviews depends on external influence which, to a large extent, cannot be trusted and may be actively used to manipulate us.
6. The world is changing faster than we can react to those changes.
7. Hyper-connectedness is obliterating our internal peace by showing us all the awful and wonderful things that are happening to people we'll never meet - whilst our lives remain fairly unchanged.
8. Popular culture is pushing us more and more towards meaningless consumption and, as such, eroding our system of values.

Alone, these might be somewhat manageable phenomena but in combination with each other, they form a vicious cocktail of effects that are making us feel tired, hopeless and ultimately confused about what the hell the point of any of our struggle is.